



BARD ON THE BEACH

New Multi-Year Agreement Framework for Main Festival Site at Vanier Park

Park Board Committee Meeting
Monday, May 25, 2026



PURPOSE/OBJECTIVES

- Present a new opportunity involving the exploration of a multi-year agreement for BOTB
- Review the needs and benefits of this initiative
- Seek the Board's approval to explore the opportunity for a period of up to 10 years



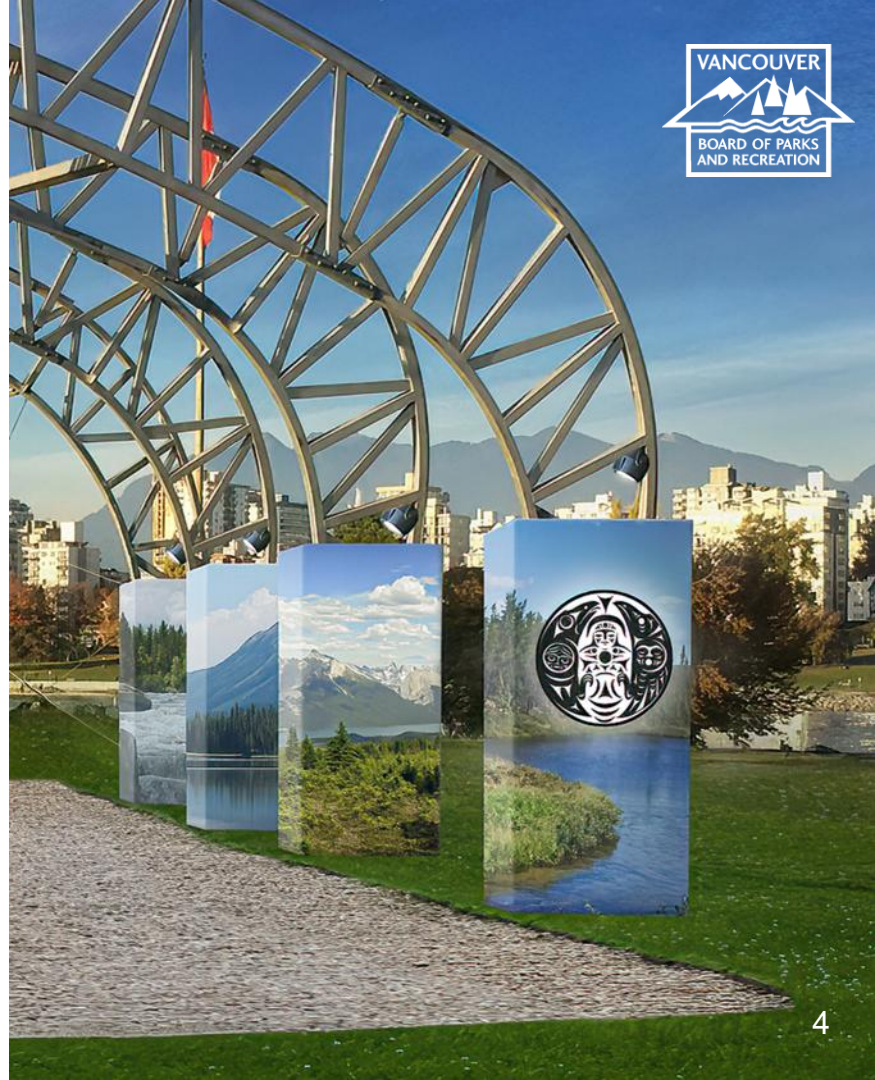
BACKGROUND | Bard on the Beach

- Established in 1990, BOTB is Western Canada's largest not-for-profit Shakespeare Festival
- Presented in Vanier Park annually
- Offers Shakespeare plays, related dramas, and special events from June to September
- BOTB educational division offers year-round program opportunities



BACKGROUND | Bard on the Beach

- Performing arts sector continues to face significant post-pandemic pressures; BOTB navigating challenging financial reality
- Board recently approved:
 - Pilot program (2024)
 - Burrard Marina space lease (2026)
- Continued focus on reducing repeatable structural costs
- New opportunity identified; long-term agreement



PROPOSAL

- Seeking Board approval to explore a broader more coordinated strategy
- Enable additional investments to enhance park usability and allow additional physical assets to remain in the park year-round
- Assets would not be permanent; would remain removable



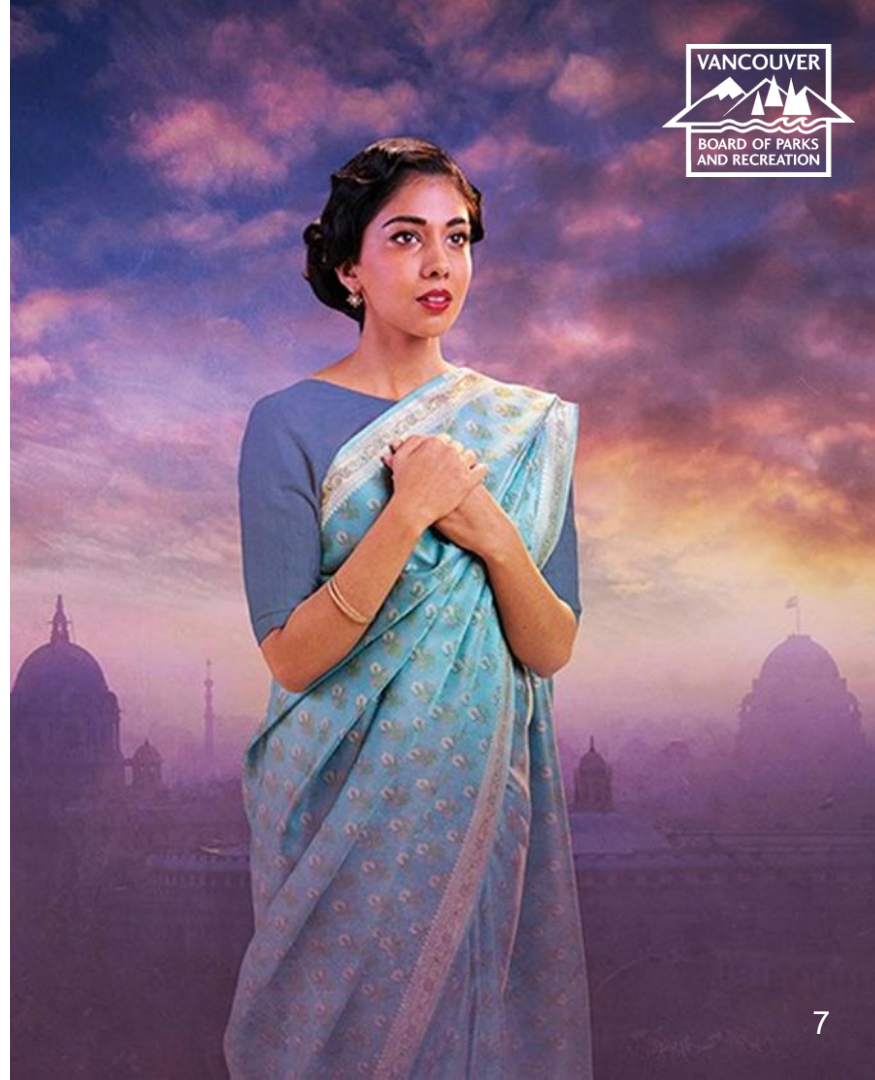
PROPOSAL

- Goals/objectives:
 - Reduce repeated annual construction and dismantling activities
 - Minimize environmental impacts
 - Lower long-term operating costs
 - Improve park usability, accessibility and public enjoyment
- Longer-term planning framework (up to 10 years) required to enable investment, cost reductions, and operational efficiencies
- Lease certainty is essential to amortize needed investments



PROPOSAL

- Potential investments to be investigated include:
 - Winterizing and retaining the Mainstage tent year-round
 - Adding anchor points for the smaller theatre tent
 - Upgrading gravel pathways for year-round use
 - Exploring a year-round marquee or covered gathering structure
 - Reimagining Bard's main entranceway
 - Investigating washroom trailer solutions



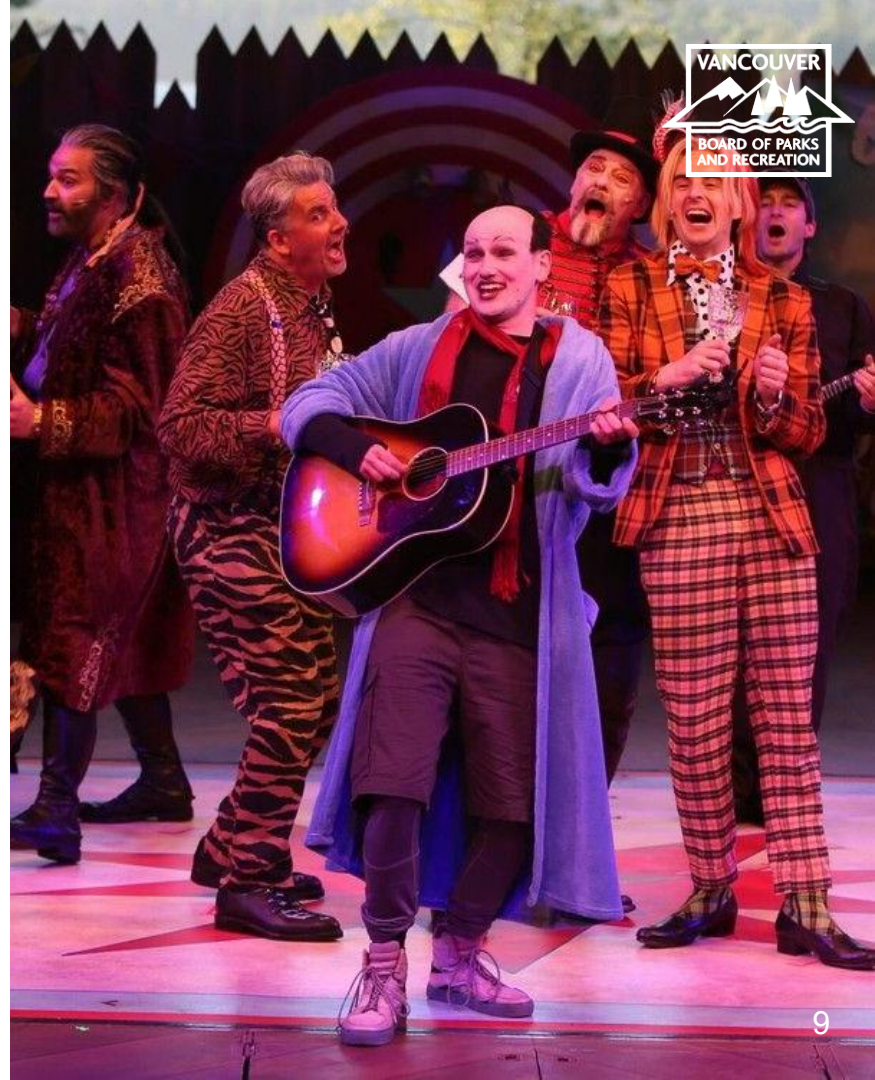
BENEFITS

- Reduce repeated construction and dismantling activities
- Reduced environmental impacts
- Enable long-term cost efficiencies
- Support a stronger, more resilient cultural partner within Vanier Park
- Improve park amenities, accessibility, and overall experience
- Enhance year-round park activation and programming
- Generate incremental revenues for Park Board



KEY CONSIDERATIONS

- Financial
 - Initiative will require investment in staff time; no incremental costs to Park Board
- Engagement
 - Internal/external stakeholders
 - MST rightsholders
- Issues/risks
 - Will need to navigate a potential longer-term agreement and the broader Vanier Park planning initiative
 - Potential community feedback



SUMMARY

- BOTB is a longstanding cultural partner
- Facing ongoing and challenging financial pressures
- New opportunity has been identified to support the Festival through the potential development of a long-term agreement of up to 10 years
- Staff have considered the many aspects of this application; confident it can be implemented successfully



RECOMMENDATIONS

- A. THAT the Vancouver Board of Parks and Recreation (“Park Board”) direct staff to explore the development of a new multi-year agreement framework for Bard on the Beach at their main festival location in Vanier Park;
- B. THAT, subject to a positive assessment, the Park Board direct staff to present the proposed terms of a new agreement framework to the Board at the earliest possible date; and
- C. THAT no legal rights or obligations shall arise, and no consents, permissions, or licenses are granted hereby, and none shall arise or be granted hereafter unless and until all contemplated legal documentation has been executed and delivered by all parties.

